- Formation of revolutionary government of National Convention. Execution of Louis XVI and proclamation of Republic in France.
- Abolition of feudalism, confiscation of church property, declaration of the rights of citizens and the introduction of a constitution
- Jacobins capturing power and the dictatorial functioning of Robespierre.
- The fall of Robespierre and the end of Revolution

I

9.1 American War of Independence

Introduction

Three great revolutions in the eighteenth century brought about striking changes in Western Society: the American Revolution, the French Revolution and the Industrial Revolution. The American Revolution was the first political revolution. Though not so vital as the French Revolution, which was to shake the social foundations of Europe, the political changes engendered by the American Revolution provided inspiration for other anti-colonial struggles.

Thomas Jefferson, who drafted the "Declaration of Independence," asserted even at the beginning of 1776 that Americans had 'neither wish nor interest to separate from English monarchy'. In July 1776 the same Jefferson got his Declaration of Independence adopted at a "Continental Congress" of the 13 colonies with its assertion that 'all men are created equal.' It was a revolutionary statement at a time when respect to kings and nobles was universal. In this lesson we trace the foundation of English colonies in America and narrate the revolt of the colonies.

Colonies of European Powers

The Portuguese and the Spanish were the pioneers in geographical explorations and the founding of colonies. The English lagged far behind in their colonisation efforts. The English possessed a theoretical claim to the North American mainland in view of the voyage of John Cabot (1497) off the coast of Nova Scotia. But they neither had the means nor the desire to back up that claim during the 16th century. Jamestown was the first British colony in America (1607). The ship *Mayflower* had taken a batch of Puritans from Plymouth, England, to America in 1620. They landed in the north and called the place New Plymouth. Another Puritan group led by John Winthrop set up the Massachusetts Bay Colony.


Ship Mayflower

Reformers who led a religious movement to reform the Church of England dispensing with the teachings and practices of Roman Catholic Church were known as Puritans. The Stuart kings, James I and Charles I, did not tolerate their attempts to reform the Church of England. The persecution of Puritans prompted many to leave England and settle. In the colonies they founded they organized a Puritan way of life.

Many other groups before the Puritans had reached other parts of the North American coastline and soon many more followed, till there were colonies dotted all over the east coast from north to south. There were catholic colonies, and colonies founded

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